

FREIE UNIVERSITÄT BERLIN



Colin Dayer

Term Paper- Summer Semester 2017-2018

Freie Universität Berlin

John F. Kennedy Institute

Department of Literature

Professor Dr. Birte Wege

Term Paper – Sommer Semester 2017-2018

Colin Dayer

Student ID 5101230

colin.dayer@gmail.com

4th semester

Table of Contents

- Abstract.....	p.3
1. Introduction.....	p.4
2. The Danger of Seeing oneself through A Mirror.....	p.4
3. Love or Death.....	p.8
4. Compassion, Empathy, Sorrow and projection.....	p.12
5. The realm of the natural world vs. The Robotization of human interaction.....	p.16
6. Conclusion:.....	p.18

Philip's K. Dick's Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep? Blade Runner, Blade Runner 2049:

Simulating Different Versions of Ourselves

Abstract

What are the implication and underlying reasons in the creation of duplicas of ourselves, the love and the sexualization of Androids. In the movie Blade Runner (1982) by Ridley Scott spectators are enticed to follow a distorted vision of their identity by projecting themselves into automated and robotic entities: it plays on the desire of a perfect connection through the possession of a machine which would be at the same times loving, unforgiving and would satisfy the human desire of possession. Love, sex and auto-identification: though it distorts the original plot, the movie plays on the way humans interpret robotic attractiveness and the way they project in them their own search for identity. Tough this “playfulness” within Blade Runner’s plot reflects an inner thrive, it does not avow itself: the desire of encapsulating the essence of the self in the creation of an automated perfect replica of ourselves and the desire of identity-control through this creation. Confronting this view with Phillippe’s K. Dick’s book *Do Android Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) that inspired Blade Brunner’s realization, I will show that Philip K Dick produces a bigger reflection about human-android projection/desire/love. Phillippe S.K. Dick shows in his book that the production of a robotic double pushes to question us about our desire to create, to produce and to copy humanity. The larger consequence of such a process would result in a loss of the natural over the fake and the imitation of reality. A simulacrum that escapes us often but symbolizes the danger of technological reproduction, duplication and human projection. Using texts by Lacan, Baudrillard, Robertson, Benesch among others, the focus of this paper will be the belief in perfect simulacra and the loss of the human identity and essence in the machine.

1. Introduction

According to a video by Vice New magazine (2018), this year the DARPA- *The Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency*- an agency that focuses on the development of emerging technologies in the U.S.A, will spend more than 28 million dollars implementing a technology that could distinguish real videos from *deepfakes videos*. Indeed, the problem of the *deepfakes* technology is that it allows a perfect replacement of a human face with a virtual one, thanks to an almost perfect synchronization of physical movements and facial expressions. This new technology contributes to feed the ongoing discussions and reflections about concepts such as *post-truth*, *fake news*, *deepfakes*, *hypernormalisation* or *simulation*. Indeed, how is it possible to distinguish what is real or fake anymore in such an environment? This situation resonates more than ever with the early prediction of Philip K. Dick in his book *Do Android Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968). In this book, the author describes a world where the fake is slowly overtaking the real human experience and where robotic entities distort reality. In his book Philip K. Dick does not only reflect upon a mere projection of the human into a robotic entity but shows that the production of a robotic double pushes us to question our own identity, and desire to create and copy humanity. Comparing Philip K. Dick's book with its two cinematographic adaptations *Blade Runner* (Scott, 1982) and *Blade Runner 2049* (Villeneuve, 2017) I will first show how this projection comes about and what it tells us about our own identity. Secondly, I will show how the creation of androids and replica of ourselves display our behavior towards sexuality and death. Thirdly, I will discuss how empathy, compassion and sorrow is distorted by the creation of androids. Finally, I will show how the realm of the natural world slowly disappears under artificiality because of the robotization of social human interactions. The larger conclusion would show that the experience of reality is diminished by the loss of the natural over the simulated and robotic reality.

2. The Danger of Seeing oneself through A Mirror

Because the bombardment of pseudo- realities begins to produce inauthentic humans very quickly, spurious humans — as fake as the data pressing at them from all sides. My two topics

are really one topic; they unite at this point. Fake realities will create fake humans. Or, fake humans will generate fake realities and then sell them to other humans, turning them, eventually, into forgeries of themselves. So, we wind up with fake humans inventing fake realities and then peddling them to other fake humans. It is just a very large version of Disneyland. (Philip K. Dick, *How to Build a Universe That Doesn't Fall Apart Two Days Later*, 1978)

In an article from 1978, Philip K. Dick explains that the two ideas that interested him the most while writing Sci-fi was “*What is reality?*” and “*What constitutes the authentic human being?*” (Philip K. Dick, 1978). In his book *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), the author explores such an issue. Indeed, the main protagonist Rick Deckard is a *bounty-hunter* and needs to kill (“retire” in the book) the Nexus-6 androids who went adrift and escaped the control of their human creators. The main problem faced by Deckard is how to distinguish them from real human as those androids are almost perfect replica of humans. In order to do so, Deckard uses the “*Voigt-Kampff Empathy Test*” (Philip K. Dick, 1968, p.29) and later on with the help of another bounty hunter uses the *Boneli Reflex-Arc Test* (Philip K. Dick, p.11). Those two tests are designed to measure the “*empathic response*” (Philip K. Dick, p.110) of an android: the android is defined as such if it fails to respond to emotional and moral stimuli within a certain time-frame. The problem with the Voigt-Kampff test is that it is designed on this lack of human responses and that this fact can also be found in “*schizophrenic human patients*” that show a “*flattening of affect*” (Dick, p.36). The issue of distinction between a real human and an android is a complicated one here, because it means that Deckard could misjudge a schizoid real human for an android (Philip K. Dick, p.36-37). In interviews conducted from 1981 to 1982 by Paul M. Sammon, Philip K. Dick states that this lack of affects would be the way he would define an android: for him the word android was “*a metaphor for people who are physiologically human but psychologically behaving in a non-human way*”. James Van Hise in an article for Starlog(1982) shows that Dick found this idea, at the origin of *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep*, when he was writing *The Man in The High Castle*(1962), an alternate history novel in which the Nazis won WWII and are ruling over the U.S.A. Dick states that he was inspired by the Nazi’s way of thinking: people who

were rational but who were lacking appropriate emotions and affects. As he studied the Nazis 'mentality, Dick states that he imagined the idea of an android as an" *highly intelligent human being who is emotionally so defective that the word human could not be applied to him*" (Philip K. Dick, 1982). In his interviews with Sammon, Dick states that developments in the creation of perfect replicas of ourselves would turn into an existence and essence struggle between androids and humans, as the two would compete against each other's. But Dick makes a very interesting point in this interview, when he states that the issue would be that the "*human would become more and more similar to the androids*" (Dick, 1982) as they struggle to match their intelligence. This fact is actually reflected in the novel as androids such as Rachael- an android who is designed by the android engineer Rosen- is treated as a real human being, given a name and programmed with the real memories of Rosen's niece (Philip K.Dick,p.56); while at the same time, humans who did not immigrate such as John Isidore in the book are treated as a sub-class and no better than androids. This can be seen when comparing an ad for an android and the job of Isidore:

the custom-tailored humanoid robot-designed specifically for YOUR UNIQUE NEEDS, FOR YOU AND YOU ALONE- given to you on your arrival absolutely free, equipped fully, as specified by you before your departure from Earth; this loyal, trouble-free companion in the greatest, boldest adventure contrived by man in modern history (Philip K. Dick, p.17)

He had been a special now for over a year, and not merely in regard to the distorted genes which he carried. Worse still, he had failed to pass the minimum mental faculties test, which made him in popular parlance a chickenhead. Upon him the contempt of three planets descended. However, despite this, he survives. He had his job, driving a pickup and delivery truck for a false-animal repair firm...*Mors certa, vita incerta*. (Philip K. Dick, p.18-19)

These passages show well that the humans are becoming as servile as androids: only serving and fulfilling automatic social functions. Isidore indeed works in a "*false-animal repair firm*" as most of the animals are dead because of the pollution on planet earth. This fact is telling as the human is now working for the supply of automated entities that imitate organic life. Also, the fact that Isidore is treated and described as" a special" resonates because he failed an IQ test. In a way, similar to tests

that Deckard uses to distinguishing the androids from human: in that sense as the human and androids are judged through computational tests, their differences become relative. The passage ends with ‘*death is certain, life uncertain*’ in Latin which resonates with the idea of distinction and identity: indeed, what defines a living being in this world, life or death? The reversion of values does not end up there: while androids are defined as lacking an empathic response, Isidore and the rest of humans in the planet cannot feel anymore and need to use a technology to fulfill their lack of social interaction and emotional exchanges. Indeed, “*the empathy box*” is a virtual reality tool that enable the user to feel an almost religious connection with other people and feel” *physical merging-accompanied by mental and spiritual identification*” (Philip K. Dick, p.21). The world described by Dick resonates with Baudrillard’s theory, where reality has become a simulation and simulacra are taken for reality (Baudrillard, *Simulacra and Simulation*, 1981). In his essay entitled *Technology, Art, and the Cybernetic Body* Benesch (2012) argues against this loss of identity in the creation of androids. For him, androids play a symbolic role in the formation of our identity and are able to “dramatize” it for us (p.11). Using Lacan’s theory of the mirror image, Benesch thinks that the android works as “*the inverted mirror images by which the continuously construes and reassures its own subjectivity*” (Benesch, p.12). Benesch concludes by stating that Deckard’s way of discerning human faces shows well the problem of identity construction and the problem of using a test that is human-based on a human-designed android:

Since the test is devised according to a preset notion of what it means to be a machine, that is, the lack of emotional responses, it is doomed to replicate endlessly the false premises of the human observer. As one of the principal androids points out, the whole design rests on an inherent paradox: by presupposing the disinterestedness and emotional aloofness of the experimenter, the Voigt-Kampff scale betrays the same psychological markers as the non-person it seeks to identify (Benesch, p.13)

As saw earlier this problem can be link with the concern of Philip K. Dick that show that the creation of androids creates a tension between humans and robotic replicas. For him, that fact was apparent and

would result for him in the impoverishment of the natural human life over the robotic life. But why are the androids appealing or repulsive to humans?

3. Love or Death

Woman and the body have shared the same servitude, the same relegation, throughout Western history. The sexual definition of woman is historical in origin: the repression of the body and the exploitation of woman were carried out in the same spirit, every exploited (and therefore threatening) category having automatically to assume a sexual definition. The repressed, sublimated sexuality of a whole civilization inevitably combines with the category whose social repression and subjection form the very basis of that culture. (Jean Baudrillard, *The Consumer Society*, p.137, 1998)

As saw earlier with Benesch, androids can be seen as a distorted creation mirroring the search for our own identity. But the android can also be a way of deciphering the way we deal with sexuality and death. One main element of the narrative of *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep* is the sexualization and objectification of the androids. This sexualization also reflects a specific sexist and gendered view, as the only androids who are sexualized are female in the book and the two movies. In the book, Deckard has a sexual relationship with Rachael who is performing this act to implicate Deckard emotionally and to stop him from retiring more androids. This part of the book would be emphasized in the two movies in which the play on sexuality is evident. The main difference between the movies and the book is that in the book, Rachael can control Deckard and replicates this situation in order to divert other bounty-hunters from their missions. Still, in the book as in the two movies, sexuality is ascribed to the robots and is programmed in them. Differences can be seen in passages from the book and dialogues in the two movies:

Deckard: Say kiss me.

Rachael: I can't rely on...

Deckard: Say kiss me.

Rachael: Kiss me.

Deckard: I want you.

Rachael: I want you.

Deckard: Again.

Rachael: I want you. Put your hands on me

(Blade Runner,1982)

“No bounty hunter ever has gone on”, Rachael said. “After being with me...

“So all that took place at the hotel”, he said, “consisted of a... (Philip K. Dick, p.183)

Ana: Replicants live such hard lives, made to do what we'd rather not

(Blade Runner,2049)

We see in those three examples that the androids are treated and perform as sexual objects or are only designed and ascribed the position of satisfying humans desire. In the dialogue of Blade Runner (1982), the only interactions between Deckard and Rachael consist of orders. As seen in the quote by Baudrillard (1988, p.137), the sexualization is only attributed to women in the three works, which reflects the sexist position and gendered attribution of those works which ascribed sexist characteristics to “female” androids. As stated by Robertson, the way of ascribing a gendered and fixed sexual role, is recurrent in the way cyborgs, androids and robots are defined in Sci-fi:

Whereas human female and male bodies are distinguished by a great deal of variability, humanoid robot bodies are effectively used as platforms for reducing the relationship

between bodies and genders from a contingent relationship to a fixed and necessary one.

(Robertson, 2010)

In a sense, *Blade Runner 2049* is pushing this interrelation between sexualization, objectification to its own limits. In the movie, the main protagonist- K- possesses a hologram which he treats as his real companion. But because it is not a physical identity, the hologram invites a real woman to synchronize with her in order to have a sexual intercourse with K. The fantasy of this kind of cinematographic representation should not trump us, it is a definite sexualization of the machine but applies to a specific way to perform sexual relationship. One of the problems in this kind of connection is that this ascribed role and relationship is biased by its apparent fakeness and needs to be overcome most of the times. In the book, Rachael notices it and said to Deckard:

it's convincing if you don't think too much about it. (Phillip K. Dick, p.178)

Even then Deckard still believes that this relationship is real, genuine and that his partner is alive:

If you weren't an android," Rick interrupted, "if I could legally marry you, I would."
Rachael said, "Or we could live in sin, except that I'm not alive." Legally you're not. But really you are. Biologically. You're not made out of transistorized circuits like a false animal; you're an organic entity." (Philip K. Dick, p.181)

This discussion raises question about the validity of Deckard evaluation and the way he performs his sexuality: how should the relationship between an android and human be perceived? Is it a perversion because of the objectification/sexualization of the android within a specific gendered category and should be seen as a display of sexist and repressed thrives? This problem should be debated as sex robots are slowly being manufactured today in California and Japan. An answer might be found in Philip K. Dick's book when he defines the limit between valid sexual intercourse and fake robotic intercourse as Rachael raises the question of pregnancy and birth:

“Androids can’t bear children,” she said then. “Is that a loss?” (...) “Is it a loss? Rachael repeated. “I don’t really know; I have no way to tell. How does it feel to have a child? How does it feel to be born, for that matter? We’re not born; we don’t grow up; instead of dying from illness or old age, we wear out like ants. Ants again; that’s what we are. Not you; I mean me. Chitinous reflex-machines who aren’t really alive” ... “*I’m not alive!* You’re not going to bed with a woman.” (Philip K. Dick, p.178)

Maybe the answer can be found in the relation of the android towards birth as it reflects broader concern about life and death. In *Blade Runner 2049*, the daughter of Deckard and Rachael who is the first android born from an android is seen as a fully existing being by K:

K: To be born is to have a soul.

(Blade Runner 2049)

In the movie, this child born from an android took the time to bury Rachael. This act is seen as deeply human in the movie as it shows a deep concern about life and death. The topic of life and death and robotic “life” expectancy is also important in the first Blade Runner:

Tyrell: I'm surprised you didn't come here sooner.

Roy: It's not an easy thing to meet your maker.

Tyrell: And what can he do for you?

Roy: Can the maker repair what he makes

Tyrell: Would you like to be modified?

Roy: Stay here. -- I had in mind something a little more radical.

Tyrell: What-- What seems to be the problem?

Roy: Death.

(Blade Runner, 1982)

FREYSA: That baby meant we were more than creations. We were creation.
More than just slaves. If a baby can come from one of us... we are our own
masters.

(Blade Runner 2049)

This shows maybe that the only difference between humans and androids in all those pieces is their relationship towards life and death. The dialogue between the designer and the Nexus 6 in the first Blade Runner is telling in that sense. Even if this scene is unique to the movie and did not exist in the book, it asks if androids reflect on their own existence and therefore believe they exist. Philip K. Dick maybe answers this question in the book when Deckard reflects on himself as being “*sub specie aeternitatis*” (Philip K. Dick, p.91), meaning according to the *Philosophy Pages* that the human existence is universal and eternally true and is not contingent/ dependent on the changes that happen throughout times and technology. Maybe, in that sense, technology in general and androids could be perceived by Philip K. Dick as only time-limited development that do not actually participate in the same universal time-frame as us. We will also see that this point is important as the android relation towards the death of a living being shows how much empathy an android can have, if any at all.

4. Compassion, Empathy, Sorrow and Projection

The desire of connection has been unmissable not that we live in an over-connected world. The “global village” as described by McLuhan has also brought disconnection as we dialogue through media separated messages and has change or way of perceiving the others. Where does compassion and empathy lie in that regard and is technology a contributing factor towards its decline? As we seen for Phillip K. Dick a feature that characterizes humanness is empathy towards another living being. This fact is one of the main twist and dilemma of the book as we seen earlier with Benesch. Indeed, Deckard needs to forget is empathy in order to retire androids. In an interview with Hise (1982), Philip K. Dick quotes this passage saying that Deckard is “*dehumanized*” by the act of having to retire androids:

You will be required to do wrong no matter where you go. It is the basic condition of life to be required to violate your own identity. At some time, every creature which lives must do so. It is the ultimate shadow; the defeat of creation. This is the curse at work, the curse that feeds on all life everywhere in the universe (Philip, K. Dick, p.164)

Reflecting on that quote Jill Gavan in her essay *Entering the Posthuman Collective in Philip K. Dick's Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1997) states that Deckard realizes at the end of the book, after finding an electric toad and experienced the killing of androids, that electric entities are alive too and that in that sense he acknowledges the existence of a posthuman collective (Galvani, p.428):

“The spider Mercer gave the chickenhead, Isidore; it probably was artificial, too. But it doesn't matter. The electric things have their lives, too. Paltry as those lives are.” (Philip K. Dick, p.222)

Going away from that fact the main issue is where does Deckard's empathy come from and what distinguishes his from the androids' way of reacting. Deckard reflects on the way the Voigt-Kampff test might be a good way to find androids and to test if they have empathy:

Empathy, evidently, existed only within the human community, whereas intelligence to some degree could be found throughout every phylum and order including the arachnida. For one thing, the empathic faculty probably required an unimpaired group instinct; a solitary organism, such as a spider, would have no use for it; in fact, it would tend to abort a spider's ability to survive. It would make him conscious of the desire to live on the part of his prey. Hence all predators, even highly developed mammals such as cats, would starve. Empathy, he once had decided, must be limited to herbivores or anyhow omnivores who could depart from a meat diet. Because, ultimately, the empathic gift blurred the boundaries between hunter and victim, between the successful and the defeated.” (Philip K. Dick, p.29)

In that sense, empathy would show that someone care about another form of life. One of the main part in the book that exemplify this is when Isidore finds a real spider and the androids decide to find whether it could still run without some of its legs. They then decide to cut some of it and see what

happen. For Isidore, this act shows a total lack of compassion towards another living being (Philip K. Dick, p.194). The reaction of Isidore is telling in that context:

In the depression caused by the sagging of the floor, pieces of animals manifested themselves, the head of a crow, mummified hands which might have once be parts of a monkeys. A donkey stood a little way off, not stirring and yet apparently alive; at least it had not begun to deteriorate. He started toward it, felling stick-like bones, dry as a weed, splinter under his shoes. But before he could reach the donkey- one of the creatures which he loved the most- a shiny blue crow fell from above to perch on the donkey's unprotesting muzzle. Don't, he said aloud, but the crow, rapidly picked out of the donkey's eyes. Again, he thought, it's happening to me again. As before. It's always long, because nothing ever changes; a point comes when it does not even decay. (Philip K. Dick, p.196)

In this passage, all things merge and are disembodied, cruelty is symbolized by the crow picking at the donkey's eyes. As we seen earlier, humans according to Philip K. Dick are becoming increasingly similar to androids as they try to match them. One step towards this is this destruction of living forms are the disappearance of real animals, which for Galvani represents in this book "*the repositories of human empathy*" (Galvani, p.415). Isidore's reaction results from the destruction of the meaning of empathy and the killing of the spider by the androids. Indeed, as shown by Galvani, most humans in the book relies on an *empathy box* that permits them to merge with Mercer who valued all form of "*living*" forms:

The legendary eponym of this widespread philosophy/religion, a figure persecuted by the authorities for bringing dead animals back to life, encourages animal ownership as a sign of his followers' moral solidarity. Those who regularly submit themselves to Mercerist "fusion" endure the utmost in human empathy: in gripping the handles of the empathy box, they experience the pain of Wilbur Mercer (Galvani, p.415)

The problem of this kind of empathy, according to Galvani, is that this fusion is a fake as Mercer is debunk later in the narrative as a charlatan that entrap people in an alienating spectacle, keeping people separated and under the fake belief of a real experience of human fusion:

The empathy box thus operates as the state's optimal homeopathic remedy: it recuperates the citizen's transgression into bounds where it can have no consequences. (Galvani, p.417)

For Galvani this fact joins Philip K. Dick's opinion that technology slowly alienates humans:

Technology thus drastically compromises an insulated human community in two ways: it separates the individual from human contact; but more significantly, it makes her dependent upon-addicted to-the life of the machine. Hooked up to her empathy box, entranced by the simulation of the television screen, the human has already, in fact, become the posthuman. (Galvani, p.418)

For Galvani, this argument tells a lot about the job Deckard has to do:

Philosophy alone will not suffice to make Rick cognizant of his material coextension with the android other. He must rather submit himself to a phenomenological experience-an experience that teaches him an empathy that is unmistakably real, insofar as it grows out of his understood intimacy with his technological environment. (Galvani, p.427)

In a lot of ways, the depiction of the androids in the two *Blade Runner* movies are humanized and show them as participating to human empathy and values, as we saw them crying and mourning the death of other androids. For example, in *Blade Runner 2049*, an android takes the time to bury Rachael

NANDEZ: He didn't seem like the saving type.

COCO: He took the time to bury her. A sentimental skinjob.

(*Blade Runner 2049*)

Or in the first *Blade Runner* the android *Batty* cries over the death of an android and then take revenge for its death on Deckard. But this understanding of the narrative might be an alternate version of the original. As we saw in the passage that depicts Isidore's reaction after the death of the spider: Isidore

starts to notice the deterioration of the form and the structure of live, as artifacts starts to dissolve into segregated items and being undistinguishable from one another. Isidore points out that with the combination of the killing of the living animals and the destruction of his virtual way of feeling empathy, the world starts to be shapeless and to lose its essence:

And the spider is gone; Mercer is gone; he saw the dust and the ruin of the apartment as it lay spreading out everywhere- he heard the kipple coming, the final disorder of all forms, the absence which would win out. (Philip K. Dick, p.195)

This fact when we link it to the character of Isidore shows well consequences of technology: a dehumanization which is connected to the destruction of empathy and its living forms. As Isidore reflects earlier in the book: “*Eventually everything within the building would merge, would be faceless and identical*” (Philip K. Dick, p.20) The destruction of empathy and the change of human into posthuman starts this process of destruction. I will show in the next chapter what Philip K. Dick means by *kipple* and the loss of the natural over the robotic.

5. The realm of the natural world vs. The Robotization of human interaction

A sense of the finiteness of the world around her. The streets and houses and cars and shops and people. Sixteen hundred people, standing in the center of a stage. Surrounded by props, by furniture to sit in, kitchens to cook in, cars to drive, food to fix. And then, behind the props, the flat, painted scenery. Painted houses set further back. Painted people. Painted streets. Sounds from speakers set in the wall. Sammy sitting alone in the classroom, the only pupil. And even the teacher not real. Only a series of tapes being played to him.” (Philip K. Dick, Time Out of Joint, p. 198)

One of the main theme of *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep* is the difference between real and fake; reality and simulation; empathy and unfeelingness. The pollution that provokes the decline of all living animals, and the emergence of androids that almost replicate humans to the perfection blur the perspective of reality of most characters within the book. As real animals became so rare, according to Galvani, for most humans, possessing a real animal conforms with the practice of *Mercersism* and also

reinforce the economic and social status of the individuals in the book (Galvani, p.424). For example, Deckard is surprised when he visits *the Rosen foundation* and hears Rachael calling her owl “it” not “her” (Philip K. Dick, p.55). Indeed, this remark is typical to pet owners who attribute a gender to their pets, but here Deckard is not sure anymore if the animal is real, owned as a pet or if it represents a sign of wealth. This fact is even more evident with the character of Isidore. Isidore works for a firm that repair false-animals (Philip K. Dick, p.18). During one of his missions, he cannot save a cat by trying to plug it to a source of energy, because the cat is actually real:

“But it’s the waste that gets me. The loss of one more living creature. Couldn’t you tell, Isidore? Didn’t you notice the difference?” (...)

“I don’t think Isidore can tell the difference,” Milt said mildly. “To him they’re all alive, false animals included. He probably tried to save it”.

He’s got a point; the fakes are beginning to be darn near real, what with those decess circuits they’re building into the new ones. And living animals do die; that’s one of the risks in owning them. We’re just not used to it because all we see are fakes.” (Philip K. Dick, p.72-73)

As it can be seen reality itself becomes a fake, as it can be seen for example in another book by Philip K. Dick *Time out of Joint* (1959): the surface of reality seems real but as soon as you scratch a little nothing makes sense anymore and everything appears as a simulation. Isidore actually has a deep understanding of it as he sees in the destruction of the form- the *kippleization*- the main reason for the ruin of reality and the disappearance of genuine human beings:

“Kipple is useless objects, like junk mail or match folder after you use the last match or gum wrappers or yesterday’s newspaper. When nobody’s around, kipple reproduces itself. For instance, if you go to bed leaving any kipple around your apartment, when you wake up the next morning there’s twice as much of it. It always gets more and more. (Philip K. Dick, p.61)

As things merge or dissolve reality becomes something else in that sense. One of the reasons that could explain why the form does not matter anymore is that maybe the world becomes more and more post-

human and inhuman as everything become a technological spectacle or simulation. Isidore as well as Deckard are saturated by medias images in the book:

I watch him while I'm eating dinner and then his late show until I go to bed. At least until my TV set broke" (Dick, p.60)

Or plugged into "mood organs" where they can dial programs to bar their "consciousness" and program their moods (Philip K. Dick, p.3). Deckard and his wife actually have this discussion about *the mood organ* and one of its mood-altering program:

"At that moment," Iran said, "when I had the TV sound off, I was in a 382 mood; I had just dialed it. So although I heard the emptiness intellectually, I didn't feel it. My first reaction consisted of being grateful that we could afford a Penfield mood organ. But then I read how unhealthy it was, sensing the absence of life, not just in this building but everywhere, and not reacting—do you see? I guess you don't. But that used to be considered a sign of mental illness; they called it 'absence of appropriate affect.' So I left the TV sound off and I sat down at my mood organ and I experimented. And I finally found a setting for despair." Her dark, pert face showed satisfaction, as if she had achieved something of worth. "So I put it on my schedule for twice a month; I think that's a reasonable amount of time to feel hopeless about everything, about staying here on Earth after everybody who's small has emigrated, don't you think?"

"But a mood like that," Rick said, "you're apt to stay in it, not dial your way out. Despair like that, about total reality, is self-perpetuating." (Philip K. Dick, p.5)

Indeed, the emergence of technology has blurred the experience of reality and people are not aware of its simulation anymore. Also, the fact that people rely on empathy box is the main paradox of the book as they are searching empathy in androids. Here we seen what Philip K. Dick stated about human losing sense of reality and their essence as they try to match the androids and technology in general. In that sense, Philip K. Dick famously responded to a student who asks him to describe what reality was in one sentence:

Reality is that which, when you stop believing in it, doesn't go away. (Philip K. Dick, How to Build a Universe That Doesn't Fall Apart Two Days Later, 1978)

Maybe the loss of the natural, universal and eternal is what happen in the creation of duplicas of ourselves, but reality is still there if we can escape the simulation of reality.

5.Conclusion: It was just a replica. No Feelings.

Androids work both as the mirrors to our identity and dangerous annihilators of what constitute the human essence. As seen, Philip K. Dick feared they would change us as we project ourselves in them and try to compete with them. Benesch showed that androids were also able to redefine our sense of self and identity. It is therefore important to remember that the way we project ourselves in androids show also how we deal with sexuality, life and death. As Baudrillard and Robertson show the sexist sexualization and objectification of robots can also be seen as a problematic as they ascribe role to perform and specific genders to androids. One related problem to that is the fact that androids are not born and cannot give birth. We saw in the book and the two movies that this reflection is fundamental and inherent in all those works. In a sense, androids can be seen as only time-limited development that do not actually participate in the same universal time-frame as us. The problem of empathy can also be highlighted as it shows that it is a defining characteristic of humanness. As the android reacts differently and imitate us, technology, if not well applied, can change the fabric of humanness into a post-humanness that starts to be faceless and without essence. Reality then becomes something blurry and humans need to plug themselves and augments themselves through technology to catch up with the loss of essence and identity. In that sense, distinction starts then to be made between the real and the fake. In that sense, in the book real animal are seen as showing a sign of cultural and economic superiority as the essence of reality slowly disappears. It is therefore important to remember than what we think of as reality can be simulated and need to be reaffirmed and revalued if we don't want to lose out on our natural world and essence. Maybe Philip K. Dick saw that we could change our world endlessly and also create our own simulation of it. He questioned our sense of reality and the way we could change it or fall for a specific one. Maybe androids reflect this broader sense of human turning

into a posthuman, reality becoming a simulation and the real becoming the fake. Reading Philip K.

Dick's work push us to ask when reality start to become a simulation or a simulacrum:

"...now I think I understand. What I was sensing was the manifold of partially actualized realities, lying tangent to what evidently is the most actualized one; the one which the majority of us by consensus gentium agree on." (Phillip K. Dick, 1977)

Bibliography

- Benesch, Klaus. *Technology, Art, and the Cybernetic Body: The Cyborg as Cultural Other in Fritz Lang's "Metropolis" and Philip K. Dick's "Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?"*. Amerikastudien / American Studies, Vol. 44, No. 3, Body/Art (1999).
- Galvan, Jill. "Entering the Posthuman Collective in Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*". Science-Fiction Studies, Vol. 24, No. 3 (Nov. 1997).
- Fancher, Hampton(Screenplay)/Scott, Ridley(Direction). *Blade Runner*. July 1982.
- Fancher, Hampton/Green, Michael(Screenplay)/Villeneuve, Denis(Direction). *Blade Runner 2049*. October 2017
- K. Dick, Philip. *Time Out of Joint* (1959). SF Masterwork, Gollancz, Orion Publishing Group. London: 2003.
- K. Dick, Philip. *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* Ballantine Books (February 26, 2008)
- K. Dick, Philip. *How to Build a Universe That Doesn't Fall Apart Two Days Later*, urbigenous.net/library/how_to_build.html.
- Baudrillard, Jean. *The Consumer Society*. English translation Sage Publications 1998. Originally published as *La Société de consommation* Editions Denoël 1970. This edition 1998, SAGE Publications: London · Thousand Oaks · New Delhi
- Baudrillard, Jean. *Simulacra and Simulation*. Originally published in French by Editions Galilee 1981
- Robertson, Jennifer. *Gendering Humanoid Robots: Robo-Sexism in Japan*. Body & Society, Sage Publication: 2010
- Lee, Jason. *Sex Robots: The Future of Desire*. 2017: Springer International Publishing AG

Videos

- Vice Magazine. *Deep fakes are becoming a real thing and it could get dangerous*, , video.vice.com/en_ca/video/deep-fakes-are-becoming-a-real-thing-and-it-could-get-dangerous/5b7b06a2be407719635331c1.
- "Rare Blade Runner Interviews with Philip K. Dick [Audio]." FilMagicians, 7 Oct. 2017, www.youtube.com/watch?v=3d7XMnmPgUk&t=90s.

Websites

- Kemerling, Garth. www.philosophypages.com, 1997-2011.
- Fischer, Michael. <https://philipdick.com/> (Last accessed on 14.09.2018)

Articles

- Van Hise, James. *PHILIP K. DICK ON 'BLADE RUNNER'*. Starlog n. 55, February 1988.
(Accessed on 14.09.2018, Scraps From The Loft :
<https://scrapsfromtheloft.com/2016/11/09/philip-k-dick-on-blade-runner/>)